

Quoridor – Python

Rapport préliminaire

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Introduction

Quoridor is an abstract strategy board game designed by Mirko Marchesi and first published in 1997 by the French company Gigamic. The game is played on a square grid and is based on two simple actions : moving a pawn and placing walls. Despite this apparent simplicity, the game exhibits a significant strategic depth, as players must constantly balance progress toward their own goal with the obstruction of their opponents.

The objective of this project is to design and implement a complete software version of the game Quoridor, supporting two, three, or four players. The program must strictly respect the official rules of the game and allow players to interact through both a command-line interface and a graphical user interface. In addition, the software must support configuration files, internationalization, and robust error handling, in accordance with the provided specifications.

This project goes beyond the development of a playable game. It aims to apply fundamental software engineering principles, including modular architecture, clear separation of concerns, automated testing, and comprehensive documentation. Quoridor also represents an interesting case study from an algorithmic perspective, as its gameplay can be naturally modeled using graph-based representations and shortest-path algorithms, which are commonly studied in computer science research.



FIGURE 1 – Figure 1 : Gigamic company (left) and Quoridor box (right)

1 Historical Background and Existing Work

Quoridor was invented by Mirko Marchesi in the mid-1990s and officially released in 1997 by the French publisher Gigamic. Since its publication, the game has gained international recognition for its elegant design and educational value, receiving several prestigious awards such as the Mensa Select Award in 1997 and the Games Magazine Game of the Year Award in 1998. Its accessibility, combined with its strategic depth, has contributed to its long-lasting popularity among both casual players and strategy game enthusiasts.

Beyond its commercial success, Quoridor has attracted attention in academic and technical contexts. The game's mechanics, which involve navigating a grid while dynamically placing obstacles, make it a natural candidate for algorithmic modeling. Several studies have explored Quoridor as a testbed for artificial intelligence, pathfinding algorithms, and adversarial search techniques.

In particular, previous academic work has shown that a Quoridor board can be represented as a graph in which vertices correspond to board squares and edges represent legal movements between adjacent squares. Wall placements dynamically modify this graph by removing edges, while pawn jumps introduce temporary alternative connections. Shortest-path algorithms such as breadth-first search or Dijkstra's algorithm are commonly used to evaluate positions, verify the legality of wall placements, and guide decision-making in artificial intelligence agents.

Notable contributions include undergraduate and master-level research that investigate heuristic evaluation functions, graph-based modeling, and search strategies for Quoridor. These works highlight the computational complexity of the game and demonstrate that, despite its simple rules, Quoridor poses non-trivial challenges for both human players and automated systems. This project builds upon these existing ideas while focusing primarily on the design of a robust, extensible, and well-engineered software implementation.

2 Classification du jeu et complexité

2.1 Classification du jeu

Jeu de stratégie combinatoire abstrait :

- Pas de thème narratif fort, pas de dés, tout repose sur la logique et les mouvements.
- Pour Quoridor, c'est un duel de pure logique.

Information parfaite :

- Aucune information cachée, chaque joueur connaît l'état du jeu à tout moment.
- Pour Quoridor, chaque joueur voit les murs adverses, les positions, le nombre de murs restants.

Déterministe :

- La résolution d'une action a un coup unique, aucun hasard.
- Implication : on peut utiliser des algorithmes comme MiniMax car on peut prévoir les coups futurs.

2.2 Complexité de l'espace d'état

La thèse de Lisa Glendenning (2005) estime l'espace d'états du Quoridor à 10^{42} configurations légales [4]. En comparaison :

- Dames : 10^{20} .
- Échecs : 10^{46} .
- Go : 10^{172} .

La complexité est proche des échecs, il est donc impossible de stocker toutes les positions en mémoire ou de résoudre le jeu par force brute (connaître le premier coup parfait dès le début).

2.3 Complexité de l'arbre de jeu et facteur de branchement

Au début d'une partie, il existe $8 \times 8 = 64$ positions possibles pour un mur, multipliées par 2 orientations, soit 128 coups légaux de placement, plus 3 déplacements possibles, pour un total de 131 coups légaux.

D'après Mertens (2006), le facteur de branchement moyen est d'environ 60, ce qui est élevé [6]. À titre de comparaison, il est d'environ 35 aux échecs (et 250 au Go). Avec un facteur de 60, la taille de l'arbre de recherche explose rapidement : à profondeur 3, on obtient $60^3 \approx 216000$ nœuds (contre environ 42000 aux échecs).

Conclusion technique : il est essentiel d'utiliser un élagage alpha-bêta et de concevoir une heuristique forte.

3 Rules of the Game

This section describes the official rules of Quoridor as implemented in this project. The objective is to provide a precise and unambiguous description of the game mechanics so that a complete game can be played without interpretation issues.

3.1 Board and Components

Quoridor is played on a square board composed of a 9×9 grid, resulting in 81 playable squares. The squares are connected orthogonally, allowing movement in the four cardinal directions. Between these squares, grooves allow walls to be placed in order to block movement.

Each player controls a single pawn. In addition, a fixed number of walls is available and distributed among the players at the beginning of the game. Walls are barriers that block movement between adjacent squares and play a central role in shaping possible paths across the board.

3.2 Initial Setup

At the beginning of the game, the board is empty except for the players' pawns, which are placed at predefined starting positions.

In a two-player game, one pawn is placed at the center square of the bottom row, while the second pawn is placed at the center square of the top row. Each player's objective is to reach any square on the opposite side of the board.

In a four-player game, pawns are placed at the center of each side of the board : one on the top, one on the bottom, one on the left, and one on the right. Each player must reach the side opposite their starting position.

In the two-player configuration, each player receives ten walls. In the four-player configuration, each player receives five walls in order to maintain balance and avoid excessive blocking.

Players alternate turns, starting with one of the players chosen according to the game configuration.

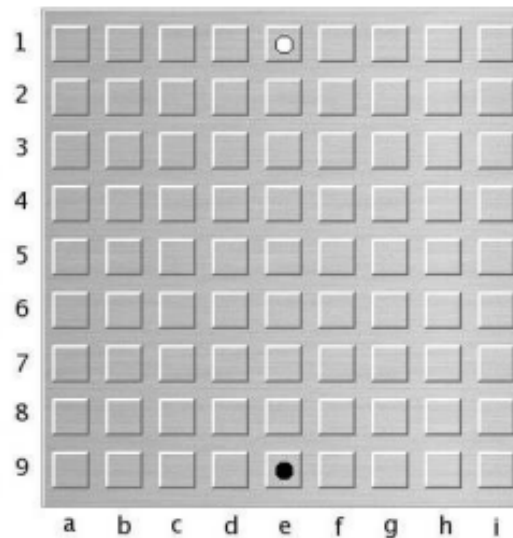


FIGURE 2 – Quoridor board layout

3.3 Pawn Movement

On their turn, a player may move their pawn to an adjacent square. Movement is allowed only in the four orthogonal directions : forward, backward, left, or right. Diagonal movement is not allowed under normal circumstances.

A pawn may only move to an adjacent square if there is no wall blocking the path between the two squares. Pawns cannot move outside the boundaries of the board, nor can they move onto a square already occupied by another pawn.

The goal of pawn movement is to progress toward the target edge of the board while navigating around walls placed by the opponents.

3.4 Jump Rules

If a pawn is located directly adjacent to an opponent's pawn and no wall separates them, the player may jump over the opponent's pawn. The jump moves the pawn to the square immediately beyond the opponent's pawn in the same direction.

If a direct jump is not possible because a wall blocks the square behind the opponent's pawn or because the board edge is reached, the player may instead move diagonally to one of the two adjacent squares to the left or right of the opponent's pawn, provided no wall blocks that diagonal movement.

In four-player games, a pawn may only jump over a single pawn per move. Multiple consecutive jumps over different pawns are not allowed.

These jump rules ensure that pawns cannot be completely blocked by the presence of other pawns and that movement remains possible even in crowded situations.

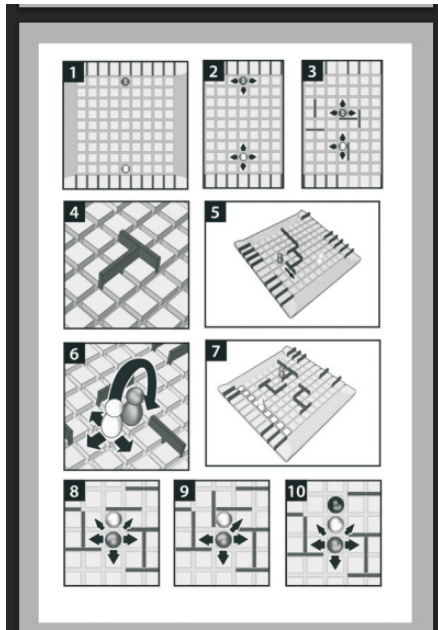


FIGURE 3 – Pawn movement

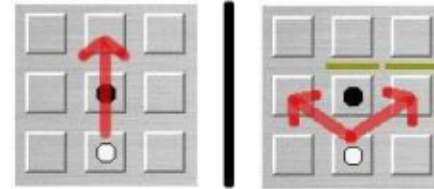


Figure 2.2: Allowed pawn jumps.



FIGURE 4 – Allowed jump

3.5 Wall Placement

Instead of moving their pawn, a player may choose to place a wall, provided they still have walls available. Walls are placed between squares and must be oriented either horizontally or vertically. Each wall spans exactly two adjacent square connections.

A wall placement must satisfy several constraints. Walls may not overlap or cross existing walls, and they must fit entirely within the board's grooves. Most importantly, a wall may not be placed if it completely blocks all possible paths for any player to reach their target side.

To ensure this rule is respected, at least one valid path from each pawn's current position to its goal edge must remain after the wall is placed. Pawn positions do not block these paths, as pawns can always be jumped over under the movement rules.

Once placed, walls are permanent and cannot be moved or removed for the remainder of the game.

3.6 Victory Condition

The game ends immediately when a player moves their pawn onto any square of their target edge. The first player to reach the opposite side of the board wins the game.

In the standard rules of Quoridor, draws are rare and generally not expected under normal play conditions, as players always have at least one legal move available until a pawn reaches its goal.

4 Algorithms and Data Structures

This section describes the data structures and algorithms selected for the implementation of the Quoridor game. The objective is to justify the chosen representations and algorithmic approaches with respect to the rules of the game and its inherent complexity, rather than to provide implementation-level details.

4.1 Board Representation

The Quoridor board is a fixed-size square grid of dimension 9×9 in the standard configuration. Each square represents a possible position for a pawn, while walls block movement between adjacent squares. Internally, the board is represented as a structured data object storing the positions of all pawns, the placement and orientation of walls, and the board dimensions.

To support efficient rule validation and path analysis, the board representation must allow fast queries about

adjacency relations between squares and the presence of blocking walls. This requirement naturally leads to an abstraction that separates static board geometry from dynamic connectivity.

4.2 Graph-Based Modeling

Following existing academic approaches, the board is modeled as a graph in which each square corresponds to a vertex and each legal movement between adjacent squares corresponds to an edge. Wall placements dynamically modify this graph by removing edges, thereby blocking movement between affected squares.

This modeling approach has been widely adopted in the literature, notably in the work of Glendenning (2005), which formalizes Quoridor as a graph-based game and uses graph traversal algorithms to analyze movement and wall legality [3]. By representing the board as a graph, pathfinding and connectivity constraints can be expressed in a uniform and well-understood framework.

Pawn positions are treated separately from walls in this model. Since pawns can be jumped over according to the rules, they do not permanently block vertices or edges in the graph and are instead handled dynamically during move validation.

4.3 Pawn Movement and Jump Handling

Basic pawn movement corresponds to traversing an edge between two adjacent vertices in the graph. Jump mechanics introduce special movement cases when two pawns are adjacent and no wall separates them. In such situations, a pawn may jump over an opposing pawn to the square immediately beyond it, provided that square is reachable.

If a direct jump is not possible due to a wall or the edge of the board, diagonal movements are permitted under specific conditions. As suggested in Glendenning’s formalization, these jump rules are not encoded directly in the static graph structure but are instead evaluated dynamically when determining the set of legal moves available to a pawn at a given state. This approach keeps the underlying graph representation simple while preserving full rule correctness.

4.4 Wall Placement Validation

Wall placement is subject to strict legality constraints. In addition to geometric restrictions such as non-overlapping and proper alignment, the rules require that every player must retain at least one valid path from their pawn’s current position to their target edge after a wall is placed.

To enforce this constraint, the proposed wall placement is simulated by temporarily removing the corresponding edges from the graph. A reachability test is then performed for each pawn to verify that a path to the goal still exists. This problem naturally reduces to a graph traversal task.

Both breadth-first search (BFS) and Dijkstra’s algorithm are suitable for this purpose. Since all movements have uniform cost, BFS is sufficient and more efficient in practice. This approach is consistent with the methods described in Glendenning (2005) and later works, which rely on shortest-path or reachability checks to validate wall placements.

If at least one path exists for every player, the wall placement is accepted; otherwise, it is rejected as illegal.

4.5 Shortest Path Evaluation

Shortest-path computations are also useful beyond wall validation. By computing the minimum number of steps required for a pawn to reach its target edge, the system can estimate player progress and relative advantage.

Such evaluations are commonly used in artificial intelligence research on Quoridor, as described by Mertens (2012), where shortest-path distances serve as heuristic features for comparing game states [7]. In the context of this project, these computations may later be reused to support automated players or provide game analysis features.

4.6 Algorithmic Complexity

Although the overall state space of Quoridor is extremely large, the algorithms used for rule enforcement operate on a fixed-size graph. The number of vertices is bounded by the number of board squares, and the number of edges is limited by local adjacency relations.

As a result, graph traversal algorithms such as BFS run in linear time relative to the size of the board and remain efficient even when executed repeatedly during gameplay. This makes the proposed approach suitable for interactive use and ensures that legality checks do not introduce noticeable delays.

4.7 Summary

The combination of grid-based data structures and graph algorithms provides a robust and conceptually clear foundation for implementing Quoridor. Modeling the board as a graph allows pawn movement, wall placement, and path validation to be handled in a unified manner using well-established algorithmic techniques. This approach is consistent with existing academic work and aligns with the goals of correctness, efficiency, and extensibility.

5 Target Architecture

The proposed architecture is intentionally minimal and organized into three main blocks to reduce dependencies and keep validation straightforward.

Core (domain) : contains the game state (board, pawns, walls) and all Quoridor rules (moves, jumps, wall placement, victory). This part has no dependency on user interfaces.

Application : orchestrates a game session (turn management, action application, global checks). It is the single entry point for the interfaces.

Interfaces : a command-line interface (CLI) and a graphical interface (GUI) that only collect player actions and display the current game state.

Dependencies go strictly from interfaces to application, then to the core. This keeps the game logic testable and independent from UI choices.

Expected core functions :

- A game service that applies an action and checks for end-of-game.
- A validation module for moves and wall placement.
- A pathfinding module (BFS) to ensure at least one path remains after any wall placement.

In practice, the UI translates user input into an action (move or wall), the application layer validates and applies it through the core, then returns the updated state back to the UI for rendering. This simple flow avoids circular dependencies and makes it easy to test the rules separately from the interfaces.

Interface (CLI/GUI) → Application → Core

This level of detail is sufficient to justify the structure without adding unnecessary complexity.

Extended Specifications

F20. Pawn Movement and Jump Mechanism

Target functionality : Allow the current player to move their pawn to a free adjacent square, or to perform a jump over an opponent if the conditions are met.

1. Prerequisites and Sub-requirements

Prerequisites :

- **F15 (Interactive Shell)** : The system must be able to receive and parse a command such as "e2-e3" or "e2-e4".
- **F26 (Graph Module)** : The board must be modeled as a graph to verify connectivity between squares.
- **F1 (Game Management)** : The game is started and it is the concerned player's turn.

Sub-requirements :

- **Parsing** : Convert alphanumeric coordinates (e.g. "e2") into graph indices or (x, y) coordinates.
- **Topological Validation** :
 - Simple case : Is the target square adjacent (distance = 1)?
 - Jump case : Is the target square at distance = 2 (aligned or diagonal)?
- **Jump Detection** : If the target is at distance 2, verify that an opponent pawn strictly occupies the intermediate square.
- **Wall Verification** : Ensure that no wall blocks the path (neither between the start and the opponent, nor between the opponent and the destination).

2. Functions and Signatures

Name : `is_move_valid`

Role : Validates whether a move (simple movement or jump) is legal according to the current board state and the opponents' positions.

Signature (Python) :

```
def is_move_valid(board: Graph, players: list, start: str, end: str) -> bool:
```

3. Unit Tests (Examples)

- **Test 1 (Simple Move) :**
 - *Input* : Player 1 at "e2", target "e3". No wall, free square.
 - *Output* : True.
- **Test 2 (Wall Obstacle) :**
 - *Input* : Player 1 at "e2", target "e3". Horizontal wall present at "e2h".
 - *Output* : False.
- **Test 3 (Valid Direct Jump) :**
 - *Input* : Player 1 at "e2", Player 2 at "e3". Player 1 targets "e4" (face-to-face configuration).
 - *Output* : True.
- **Test 4 (Blocked Jump) :**
 - *Input* : Player 1 at "e2", Player 2 at "e3". Player 1 targets "e4". A wall is present behind Player 2.
 - *Output* : False (The jump is not possible).

Conclusion

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A Section en annexe

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